

COVENANT RELATIONSHIPS THAT CREATE A CULTURE OF BRINGING

Mark 2:1-12 (KJV) *“And again he entered into Capernaum after some days; and it was noised that he was in the house. 2 And straightway many were gathered together, insomuch that there was no room to receive them, no, not so much as about the door: and he preached the word unto them. 3 And they come unto him, bringing one sick of the palsy, which was borne of four. 4 And when they could not come nigh unto him for the press, they uncovered the roof where he was: and when they had broken it up, they let down the bed wherein the sick of the palsy lay. 5 When Jesus saw their faith, he said unto the sick of the palsy, Son, thy sins be forgiven thee. 6 But there was certain of the scribes sitting there, and reasoning in their hearts, 7 Why doth this man thus speak blasphemies? who can forgive sins but God only? 8 And*

immediately when Jesus perceived in his spirit that they so reasoned within themselves, he said unto them, Why reason ye these things in your hearts? 9 Whether is it easier to say to the sick of the palsy, Thy sins be forgiven thee; or to say, Arise, and take up thy bed, and walk? 10 But that ye may know that the Son of man hath power on earth to forgive sins, (he saith to the sick of the palsy,) 11 I say unto thee, Arise, and take up thy bed, and go thy way into thine house. 12 And immediately he arose, took up the bed, and went forth before them all; insomuch that they were all amazed, and glorified God, saying, We never saw it on this fashion.”

The truth of being in a covenant relationship with family, friends, coworkers and acquaintances that demands a culture of bringing is nowhere more beautifully illustrated than in the story of a paralyzed

man who had some friends with enough compassion and faith to bring him to Jesus.

What a glorious example of covenant friendship. We could all use four friends like that, couldn't we?

Samuel Coleridge wrote a poem titled: "*Youth and Age*" and in it is a particular term, "*Friendship is a sheltering tree.*" That is a wonderful word picture. Friends are those whose lives are like branches:

- They provide shade...
- They provide refuge from the demanding, irritating and searing rays of the hot sun...
- You can find comfort when in close proximity to them...
- They bear fruit that provides nourishment and encouragement...

Isn't it interesting that when something occurs in your life and you are alone, you

pick up the phone and call a friend? (You use the lifeline of a friend)

Few things are lonelier than going through a sudden test or having something to celebrate and having no one to call.

(TALK ABOUT THIS MAN'S CONDITION – HAVE 4 PEOPLE BRING A PERSON IN ON A STRETCHER AND SET HIM ON THE STAGE)

(TALK ABOUT THIS ACTION GOING BEYOND THE NORMAL PARAMETERS OF NORMAL FRIENDSHIP – THIS IS COVENANT FRIENDSHIP)

Covenant friendship requires...

COMPASSION

Somebody had to look upon this man's plight and have the heart to care! The King James Version says "He was sick of the *palsy*." One translation says he was a

“paralytic.” This word for *“palsy”* technically means that the muscles of the body are not working in harmony, making proper movement impossible. The *“palsy”* might often include muscle tremors. This man was not likely simply lying in a simple, immobile state, it’s likely that his torment in not being able to move about was made worse by the discomfort of tremors.

Knowing his condition, I am quite sure he was SICK of the palsy! More importantly he had four friends that were also SICK of the palsy! What are you SICK of that is going on in your:

- Family...
- Workplace...
- Friendships...

Everywhere we look there are people who are paralyzed by:

- Sin...
- Bondage...

- Oppression...
- Spiritual ignorance...
- Physical infirmity...
- Demonic possession...

Clif High www.coinbase.com

Please notice, the Bible say's there were so many people in the house that no one else could enter so these guy's "***Tore the roof off...***" This action tells us that there was more than a friendship – There was true compassion! Their compassion disregarded:

- The personal property of the homeowner...
- The attitudes of those in the house...
- The cost of repairs...

Are you as sick of the palsy as I am? I hope we are so sick of the palsy that it will stir in us a compassion that drives us to covenant with one another to BRING our acquaintances to church and a life group.

We must create a culture of BRINGING at CT Church!

Covenant friendship requires...

FAITH

Hebrews 11:1 (CEV) *“Faith makes us sure of what we hope for and gives us proof of what we cannot see.”* It’s not enough simply to feel sorry for the poor man who is SICK of the palsy! Somebody has to mix action with their compassion, but it takes faith to carry them to Jesus. Hebrews 11:6 (CEV) *“But without faith no one can please God. We must believe that God is real and that he rewards everyone who searches for him.”*

Jesus certainly saw action, but more than that He saw their faith. There was evidently a covenant of faith between these men and the guy who was SICK of the palsy!

I do not know if the man on the stretcher had faith. The Bible does not say. This I know, the men carrying the stretcher had faith!

Notice, each action they took screams faith:

- They contacted their sick friend...
- They acquired a stretcher...
- They convinced the man to go to see Jesus...
- They BROUGHT the man to see Jesus...
- They tore the roof off...
- They lowered him to the spot where Jesus was ministering...

Each action was an action of faith!

Who is in our circles of influence that needs a miracle from Jesus? Are we willing to take our friendship with them from a level of acquaintance to the level of a covenant relationship to see them helped?

If we can get our paralyzed friends into the presence of Jesus, then Jesus will do something about their situation!

Faith is a disposition of the mind that provokes action! Faith:

- Provokes prayer...
- Provokes giving...
- Provokes obedience...
- Provokes persistence...
- Provokes evangelism...
- Provokes action...

Are you as sick of the palsy as I am? I hope we are so sick of the palsy that it will stir in us to a place of faith that drives us to covenant with one another to BRING our acquaintances to church and a life group.

We must create a culture of BRINGING at CT Church!

A culture of invitation will often be met with...

RESISTANCE

Please know, when we step up to the plate and covenant to do our part to BRING people to church and a life group we will definitely meet with some resistance. There will be the resistance of:

- Inconvenience... They had to carry this man to Jesus. We must be willing to bear each other's burdens – even to bear each other! There was the inconvenience of the crowd. There was too many people pushing and shoving to get to Jesus. This meant they had to go up to the roof and literally break through the roof! They had to scrape or dig through the overlying covering of dried clay to remove roof tiles and lower the man in.
- Religious spirits... Jesus did not say to the man “*Rise and be healed...*” He said, “*Thy sins be forgiven thee...*” The

Scribes, religious leaders of the day, questioned the authority of Jesus to forgive this man's sins. They reasoned in their hearts – they had a conversation within themselves – and considered Jesus a blasphemer. Religious spirits always question anyone who offers a challenge to the parameters of the past! Creating a culture of invitation flies in the face of “*Business as usual in the church.*”

Because the four friends were willing to push through the resistance they were able to get their friend to Jesus.

Are you as sick of the palsy as I am? I hope we are so sick of the palsy that it will stir in us to push past the resistance of creating a culture of invitation.

We must create a culture of BRINGING at CT Church!

Covenant friendship results in...

REVELATION

These friends brought the man to Jesus for a physical healing. He received his healing but he got more than he or they bargained for!

Ephesians 3:20 (NKJV) ***“Now to Him who is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us.”***

The faith of these friends created a context for the Lord Jesus Christ to not only display His healing power but also His redemptive power! He not only got healed, he got saved! ***“Thy sins be forgiven thee...”***

The miracle Jesus performed here went beyond a miracle of healing to a moment of revelation for:

- The man...
- The friends...

- The crowd...

As a result of all this, the text says that all who witnessed it were “*amazed...*” The Greek word translated “*amazed*” here means to remove something out of its place, to be out of one’s mind, or be transported beyond oneself with astonishment. In our modern way of saying it, the people were beside themselves!

The four friends gave God an opportunity to reveal who Jesus was by BRINGING this man to Christ. It is time for us to create a culture of invitation and give God the chance to prove himself to our friends who are stricken with the palsy!

2017 must be the year we create a culture of invitation to our palsied friends to attend a life group and/or a church service.

CONCLUSION:

These four friends had a covenant of faith with Jesus.

- Will you carry others to Jesus in prayer?
- Will you carry others to church?
- Will you carry others to Life Groups?
- Will you carry the testimony of Jesus' goodness in your mouth and share it with whomever you can

FACILITATORS QUESTIONS:

- 1) What was the physical problem with the man who needed a miracle? (*He was stricken with palsy*)
- 2) What did palsy look like as it manifested itself in the physical body of this man? (*He was paralyzed and experienced tremors – Much like a severe case of Parkinson's disease*)
- 3) How many people were involved in bringing the palsied man to Jesus? (*Four*)
- 4) What four things were required of these four man in order for their friend

to receive a miracle? (*Compassion – Faith – Resistance – Revelation*)

- 5) How can we allow compassion to be extended through us to those in our circle of influence who are paralyzed by sin or their circumstances? (*Talk through how each person can develop an action plan of going after a person who is in need of what God can give them*)
- 6) How can we develop faith (Our nerve) to become a bringer? (*Prayer – Develop a target list – Develop action items to show compassion – Gather the nerve (faith) to start the process*)
- 7) How can we prepare ourselves for the resistance we will meet? (*Pray – Have a made up mind to do this no matter what – Continue inviting and doing acts of compassion in spite of the resistance*)
- 8) What do we mean by “revelation” in this context? (*Revelation means that*

*our friends who have been paralyzed
by disease or circumstances of life
have been brought into the presence of
Jesus)*